

He stopped, then added, in a calmer tone: “But, *mon cher ami*, let me tell you *quelque chose* [uttered very slowly, with his thumb hitting his index and middle fingers]: had you grown up in a Protestant society where people are told that efforts are linked to rewards and individual responsibility is emphasized, you would never have seen the world in such a manner. You were able to see luck and separate cause and effect *because* of your Eastern Orthodox Mediterranean heritage.” He was using the French *à cause*. And he was so convincing that, for a minute, I agreed with his interpretation.

We like stories, we like to summarize, and we like to simplify, i.e., to reduce the dimension of matters. The first of the problems of human nature that we examine in this section, the one just illustrated above, is what I call the *narrative fallacy*. (It is actually a fraud, but, to be more polite, I will call it a fallacy.) The fallacy is associated with our vulnerability to overinterpretation and our predilection for compact stories over raw truths. It severely distorts our mental representation of the world; it is particularly acute when it comes to the rare event.

Notice how my thoughtful Italian fellow traveler shared my militancy against overinterpretation and against the overestimation of cause, yet was unable to see me and my work without a reason, a cause, tagged to both, as anything other than part of a story. He had to *invent* a cause. Furthermore, he was not aware of his having fallen into the causation trap, nor was I immediately aware of it myself.

The narrative fallacy addresses our limited ability to look at sequences of facts without weaving an explanation into them, or, equivalently, forcing a logical link, an *arrow of relationship*, upon them. Explanations bind facts together. They make them all the more easily remembered; they help them *make more sense*. Where this propensity can go wrong is when it increases our *impression* of understanding.

This chapter will cover, just like the preceding one, a single problem, but seemingly in different disciplines. The problem of narrativity, although extensively studied in one of its versions by psychologists, is not so “psychological”: something about the way disciplines are designed masks the point that it is more generally a problem of *information*. While narrativity comes from an ingrained biological need to reduce dimensionality, robots would be prone to the same process of reduction. Information *wants* to be reduced.

To help the reader locate himself: in studying the problem of induction in